GOPHISH- Simulated Phishing Campaign

- Abhinav V R

Overview:

The phishing simulation campaign was conducted using Gophish, an open-source phishing framework, running inside a virtual machine (VM) environment. The objective was to test organizational susceptibility to phishing attacks and demonstrate the process of launching a simulated phishing attack for awareness and training.

Setup and Configuration:

- Gophish was installed on a Windows/Linux VM.
- Accessed the Gophish web UI at https://localhost:3333.
- Created custom phishing email templates mimicking common attack types.
- Developed realistic landing pages for credential capture demonstrations.
- Added a test group of recipient email addresses for campaign targeting.

Campaign Execution:

- The campaign was launched targeting the test recipient group.
- Phishing emails were sent in the background using Gophish's SMTP profile.
- Real-time tracking showed email opens, link clicks, and credential submissions.

- Monitoring was done through the Gophish dashboard with timelines per recipient.

Results and Observations:

- A measurable number of recipients opened the phishing email.
- Several recipients clicked on the phishing links redirected to custom landing pages.
- Some recipients submitted credentials (simulated confidential information).
- Activity timeline showed detailed steps for each recipient from email delivery to form submission.
- Data was exported for analysis and training follow-up.

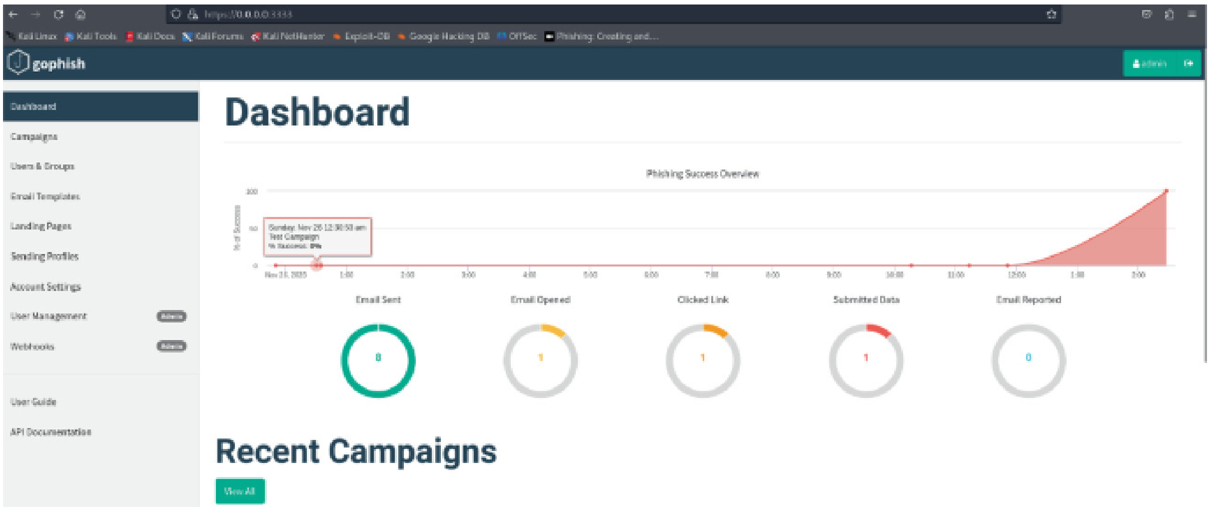
Educational Impact:

- Simulated phishing highlighted common user vulnerabilities.
- Enabled training users to identify suspicious emails and avoid credential sharing.
- Encouraged establishing a reporting culture for suspicious emails.
- Demonstrated the value of ongoing phishing drills for security awareness.

Limitations and Ethical Notes:

- Campaign was run in a closed environment with explicit permission.
- Real-world phishing campaigns should adhere to legal and ethical standards.
- Simulation effectiveness depends on realistic templates and targeted user groups.

Screenshots:



Conclusion:

Gophish in a VM environment highlights the vital role this tool plays in strengthening cybersecurity awareness within organizations. Running such ethical phishing campaigns reveals employee vulnerabilities to phishing attacks, enabling IT teams to tailor targeted training to close security gaps. Gophish’s ease of use, flexible customization, and real-time analytics empower organizations to identify risks early and proactively improve human defenses against phishing threats. By simulating realistic phishing scenarios, organizations foster a security-conscious culture that significantly reduces the chances of falling victim to real-world attacks. When deployed responsibly and ethically, Gophish proves to be an essential, cost-effective solution for ongoing cybersecurity education and risk management